

Napoleon Bonaparte was born on August 15, 1769, in Corsica. He graduated from the École Militaire in Paris in 1785 as an artillery officer. His military career took off in 1793 when he gained recognition for recapturing Toulon from the British. In 1795, he suppressed a royalist uprising in Paris, earning him command of the French Army of Italy. Between 1796 and 1797, he led successful campaigns in Italy, defeating Austrian forces. In 1798, he invaded Egypt to weaken British influence but suffered a naval defeat at the Battle of the Nile. In 1799, he overthrew the French government in the Coup of 18 Brumaire and became First Consul of France. By 1804, he had declared himself Emperor of France after a national referendum. One of his greatest victories came in 1805 at the Battle of Austerlitz against Austria and Russia. However, his fortunes changed in 1812 when he invaded Russia, suffering a disastrous defeat due to the harsh winter and Russian tactics. By 1814, after losing the War of the Sixth Coalition, he was forced to abdicate and was exiled to Elba. He returned to power in 1815 for what became known as the Hundred Days but was ultimately defeated at the Battle of Waterloo by the British and Prussians. He was exiled to the remote island of Saint Helena, where he died on May 5, 1821.